

ANNA NAGAR

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'SLOWED DOWN' BY FAST LOCAL TRAINS

As they chug in from Arakkonam and Tirutanni and head towards Chennai Central, fast local trains do not have a platform on the fast line to halt at Ambattur railway station. **P2**



YOUNG VOICES FOR ORGAN DONATION

Through 'Angels of Change', Chennai-based Mohan Foundation is raising youngsters to serve as advocates for organ donation. **P4**

'Pedestrians in peril at Manikandapuram junction'

This is a school zone; but the junction lacks safety measures



Manikandapuram junction in Thirumullaivoyal on CTH Road.

You can be our volunteer writer

Dear readers, you can be our volunteer-writer by writing to us about issues and events in your neighbourhood. You should send the write-ups to down-townfeedback@thehindu.co.in. Letters must carry the contact number



D. SURESH

Vehicular and pedestrian signals are needed at the section of CTH Road cutting through Manikandapuram in Thirumullaivoyal. For the many years now, residents have been crossing the road near HP petrol bunk, though the gaps in the median. Recently, these gaps have been closed to prevent jaywalking and pedestrians are expected to cross the road near the arch of the Mangalam hall.

But the spot near the arch is chaotic as motorists cross the road here. Pedestrians, especially senior citizens, are in peril due to constant movement of vehicles. Traffic police regulate the junction during peak hours. When they are not around, this section gets really unsafe. There are speed-breakers at the junction but traffic signals are also needed.

This is a school zone. It also boasts a college. MTC buses frequent this road.

Further, pedestrians try to jump over the closed-section of the median to cross the



road, making the move to close the gaps at the junction futile. Traffic police should look into this issue.

D. Suresh is a resident of Thirumullaivoyal



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‘Slowed down’ by fast local trains

As they chug in from Arakkonam and Tirutanni and head towards Chennai Central, fast local trains do not have a platform on the fast line to halt at Ambattur railway station. As a result, commuters taking these trains to reach Ambattur have to do an extra train trip on the suburban line. Workers at the factories in the Ambattur Industrial Estate taking these fast locals are said to be among those affected. Ambattur Rail Commuters Welfare Association wants Southern Railway to carry out yard remodelling and provide this much-needed platform

PRINCE FREDERICK

In the factories at Ambattur Industrial Estate, one reason for punching in late always holds water, all the water from the 173-hectare Ambattur Eri. The late-arriving staffer just needs to mumble a two-word response, “fast local”, and walk past the supervisor without waiting for the reaction, which is predictable anyway. The supervisor would nod knowingly and return to the work at hand; no more questions for the late-comer to fend off. The fast local trains from Arakkonam and Tirutanni heading towards Chennai Central “slow down” those with Ambattur as destination when the home stretch is in sight, hence this rare understanding from supervisors and bosses.

This is not an error of commission but omission. The fast locals chug as swiftly as ever, but they glide past Ambattur railway station, ignoring it with the disdain of a privacy-valuing celebrity for paparazzis. They stop beyond, at Villivakkam station, and these commuters

have to cross over to the other side, take a regular suburban train to Ambattur. Long-distance commuters heading to addresses in Ambattur that have boarded the Yelagiri Express are also subjected to that extra train trip, but from Perambur railway station, as this service halts there, after giving Ambattur railway station the cold shoulder.

By any chance, if these fast locals are behind schedule due to challenges on their routes, that extra train trip would be the proverbial last straw that broke the camel’s back, says L. Saravanan, president of Ambattur Rail Commuters Welfare Association.

That is the long explanation for why “fast locals” are synonymous with late punch-ins at the factories in Ambattur Industrial Estate. This writer assumes readers know this is a hyperbolic narration of an everyday problem for workers travelling long on the rails to their workspaces in Ambattur Industrial Estate. They may not be serial late punchers, but having to do that extra train trip is a strain on their mind, if not their body as well. The point, according to Saravanan, is that many workers from the factories

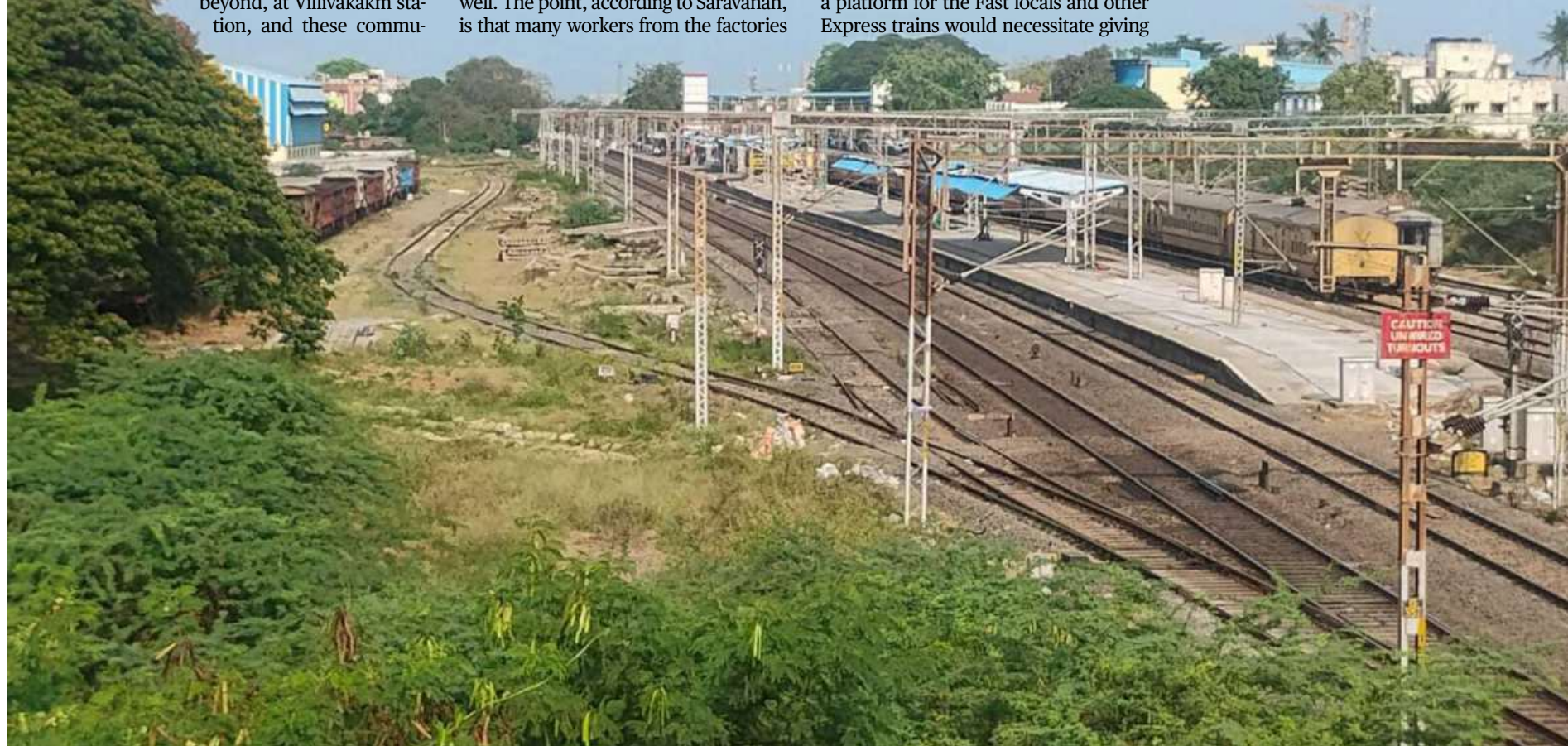
of Ambattur Industrial Estate depend on the fast locals to get to work, hence the demand that these fast locals halt here.

To the question why these fast locals do not oblige these commuters, the answer is simple: they cannot. There is no platform on the fast line at the Ambattur railway station for them to halt. On the return trip, when they trundle out of Chennai Central and head back to the other end of their travel band, namely Arakkonam, Tirutanni and Yelagiri, they stop at Ambattur railway station. They stop there, because they can. A platform has been provided for these fast locals (including the Yelagiri Express) on this side. Saravanan notes that the Arakkonam-bound fast local called 7:10 (called so because it leaves Chennai Central at that time in the evening) alone does not halt; all other fast locals do, on this side. What is keeping Southern Railway from extending the same gesture to those travelling into Ambattur? Saravanan notes that Southern Railway baulks at the idea as construction of a platform for the Fast locals and other Express trains would necessitate giving

up a loop line. He notes that rail commuter groups, including the one he heads, are certain there is enough space to create a platform for these trains without disturbing the loop line, and that Southern Railway is reluctant to consider the option. When Ambattur rail commuters pressed for this option to be exercised, Saravanan says Southern Railway replied that the said space is sufficient only for the construction of a platform that can accommodate 22 coaches. Construction of a platform for 24-coach trains would necessitate yard remodelling.

Ambattur rail commuters want yard remodelling to be carried out. Saravanan notes that assuming a platform for 22 coaches is constructed now, the entire process would have to be restarted during yard remodelling as it involves repositioning of track junctions. So the best approach, in his eyes, is for Southern Railway to undertake yard remodelling now.

AMBATTUR RAILWAY STATION



As new bridges come up, this road is in focus

UMANATH V.

Two new bridges originating at Poonamallee High Road that are designed to ease traffic movement in interior sections of Mogappair and Nolambur might end up aggravating the congestion problem they are meant to resolve. The likely fallout would not result from any factor intrinsic to these two bridges, but one extraneous to them.

Nolambur Union Road running along the Cooum river bank has the weighty task of distributing traffic from these two bridges into the interior roads. And this road resembles a poorly squeezed toothpaste tube, narrow in parts, in one place as narrow as 18 feet. This road has wider sections, which amounts to zero benefit, as the congestion in the narrow sections would have a ripple effect affecting them too. Encroachments along the Cooum river bank are taking bites out of Nolambur Union road.

Let us now step back and take in these two bridges, one inaugurated and the other nearing completion.

Opened six months ago, the first bridge connects Poonamallee High Road with Chinna Nolambur. The second bridge, larger and under construction, links Maduravoyal Ration Shop area on Poonamallee High Road to Nolambur Union Road. Roughly around 500 to 700 metres would separate the two bridges.

These bridges are aimed at providing a fluid road trip for residents in the interior sections of Mogap-



pair and Nolambur to Poonamallee High Road. It is clearly a shorter, therefore quicker route to the arterial road. At present, these residents hugely rely on the service lane of the 200-foot Bypass Road, and this route is circuitous requiring motorists to drive in the opposite direction for around two kilometres before turning towards Poonamallee High Road.

To cut a long story short, these two bridges would serve their intended purpose only if attention is paid to the bottlenecks on Nolambur Union Road running along the Cooum river bank. There is a plan to widen the road, clearing encroachments on the river bank but this is yet to translate into action.

With the other bridge nearing completion, it is high time this plan is carried out.

(Umanath V. is a resident of Nolambur)



A narrow section of Nolambur Union Road; and an aerial view of a wide section.
PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Fundraiser event to support a charitable home

Shanthi Bhavan, a charitable home providing free residential care to aged destitute, is having a fundraiser to raise money to upgrade its current facility at Sholavaram.

'Birds of Border', a theatrical production by Ekatha, will be staged at Museum Theatre on March 21 and 22.

The play is a moving and thought-provoking performance that explores themes of love, compassion, emotional resilience, and the breaking of human boundaries.

Shanthi Bhavan currently supports 50 elderly residents, many of whom were referred by hospitals, police and local authorities. They are given free accommodation, meals, medical care and emotional support. Under 'Mission 100' it plans to expand the capacity of the Bhavan to accommodate 100 residents. The project seeks CSR support from corporate partners and philanthropists to build new residential facilities, strengthen health and emergency support, and implement green, cost-saving solutions such as solar power, biogas and eco-friendly sanitation, said a release.

For details, call 9005008736 / 9789376357; Website: www.shanthibhavan.org

'Ambattur OT bus stop lacks shelter'

T. GUNASEELAN

The bus stop attached to the Ambattur OT bus terminus on CTH Road in Ambattur (meant for buses toward Avadi) lacks a shelter. Therefore, commuters have to brave the rain and the blazing sun. This stop witnesses a good number of commuters as buses to Avadi and Poonamalle halt here. This includes both ordinary and deluxe buses. Hence the need for a shelter.

It may be noted the stop which was near Shopping Singapore was shifted a few metres away a couple of weeks ago. Buses now halt near Apollo Pharmacy. The



move was aimed at reducing traffic congestion near Shopping Singapore which is a junction of Ambattu-Puzhal Road and CTH Road and hence caused bottlenecks. The shifting of the stop shows the need for wi-

dening CTH Road. Many years ago, there was a bus stop opposite Ambattur OT bus terminus and that was quite convenient for commuters who wanted to access the OT terminus. Commuters had to just cross the

road. To avoid a bottleneck, that got shifted near Shopping Singapore and now it has been moved further. Hence, CTH Road should be widened.

T. Gunaseelan is a resident of Ambattur

Young voices for organ donation

Through 'Angels of Change', Chennai-based Mohan Foundation is raising youngsters to serve as advocates for organ donation



LIFFY THOMAS

When a biology lesson on organ systems generated immense interest among Class VIII students of The Pupil International School, the biology teacher Mathura saw an opportunity for an extended class, one about organ donation helmed by subject matter experts from Mohan Foundation. The session eventually led to the formation of Organ Donation Awareness Club led by 25 Class VIII students.

In February, the Club conducted an awareness campaign at the school with a skit and a song, thoughtfully executed by the students to engage their peers. A short film *Second Beat* with students, parents and teachers as actors sends out a powerful message on grief, hope and courage inherent in the process of organ donation.

As an extension of Club's activities, students are reaching out to the communities around them. In a rangoli competition at her gated community in Iyyappanthangal, Aadhira K. drew a design to draw residents' attention to organ donation. Her classmates Deepthi T. has met 15 residents at her gated community in Porur to throw light on organ donation. And Shivam S. along with a group is getting a skit on the topic ready to present it at a city college.

Mohan Foundation, a Chennai-based non-profit promoting organ donation, transplantation and public awareness started 'Angels of Change' before the pandemic to encourage young voices to become advocates for the cause. Over the last two years, this programme has been customised for school students, and it travels across the country.

Before the pandemic, students of Punjab Association Group of Schools in Chennai signed up for the 'Angels of Change' programme. Two schools from Delhi have initiated this programme for their highschoolers. Likewise, Mumbai also has schools that are showing interest in running this programme as a club activity.

Hemal Kanvinde, Quality Assurance Officer, Mohan Foundation, says some students sign up as individuals, either taking it up during their summer or winter break or as an internship.

A student volunteer from Dubai (now pursuing her MBBS), who completed the programme, went on to receive The Diana Award.

"The motivation to sign up for this programme is different, some are drawn by an incident in the family, some to engage in a meaningful act of service as part of their curriculum and many out of curiosity," says Hemal.

"We support them 2-3 times before we let them do activities on their own," says Hemal, inviting more schools to be part of the



Aadhira K from Iyyappanthangal drew this rangoli at a competition in her gated community to raise awareness about organ donation; and (above) the batch performs a skit.

programme.

The Foundation also runs an Ambassador programme, which is open to students and adults.

Legacy club

The Foundation is also working on putting Angels of Change as a

legacy club in school, so that the initiative gets passed on from one batch to another.

Dr. Saveetha, director, The Pupil International School, says the idea to start an organ donation awareness club came from the students and we want them to

The programme

The Angels of Change programme has three modules. The first one is an online programme, which essentially functions as a primer on organ donation. The three-to-four-hour course also covers FAQs that children can prepare themselves for while talking to others.

The second part is conducted in person and involves meeting a recipient, donor and talking to experts, an example being a grief counsellor. The last part deals with ways to engage in positive conversations and the right vocabulary that must be used. For example, saying "organs were harvested" is not saying it in an acceptable manner.

Following the completion of the course, participants get a kit comprising IEC materials, donor card and flyer. The participants are expected to conduct two public awareness talks or campaigns such as a poster competition, debate, awareness talk in their parents circle, done under the guidance of Mohan Foundation staff as part of the completion of the training.

For details, write to info@mohanfoundation.org

handhold their juniors to carry forward the activities they began. We are working out a plan to see how the regular activities can be conducted from the coming academic year.

Recognising the Unrecognised

The third edition of Rotary Club of Madras Metro's Spirit of India Awards 2026 honoured four individuals from four cities



The awardees seen with Veeraraghav, Executive Editor, NDTV (3rd from left); Dr. Vijaya Bharathi Rangarajan (3rd from right); Club President Mahesh Krishna (2nd from right); Club Secretary Binny Rajkumar (extreme right); Suresh Jain (2nd from left) and Ram Kumar P T (extreme left)

The Rotary Club of Madras Metro presented the 3rd Edition of the Spirit of India Awards 2026, a pan-India initiative dedicated to "Recognising the Unrecognised" – individuals who have made extraordinary contributions to the society, often away from the public spotlight, on March 13 at Madras Management Association.

The event was graced by T. M. Veeraraghav, Executive Editor, NDTV, as the chief guest, and Rtn Dr. Vijaya Bharathi Rangarajan, District Governor Elect, 2027 - 28 as the guest of honour.

The winners are: Chandana Sinha, Inspector, RPF (Guardian of Hope), Lucknow, for her exem-

plary service in protecting vulnerable children and ensuring safety and dignity within the railway ecosystem; Jagriti Mishra, animal activist from Delhi, recognised for her relentless dedication to animal welfare and advocacy for the protection and humane treatment of animals; P. Naveen Kumar, Champion of Dignity from Erode, was acknowledged for his inspiring work in empowering communities and upholding human dignity through social initiatives; and Dr. Suneela Kumar Hebhi - Healing Beyond Boundaries, Bengaluru, for his compassionate medical service and commitment to providing healthcare that reaches

beyond conventional limits.

The Spirit of India Awards initiative by the Rotary Club of Madras Metro aims to spotlight unsung heroes across India whose courage, compassion, and commitment make a meaningful difference in society, said a release.

Through this platform, the club continues its mission of promoting humanitarian values and encouraging individuals who work tirelessly for the welfare of others without seeking recognition.

The president of the club A. S. Mahesh Krishna expressed that these awards serve as a reminder that true heroes often work silently, driven only by the spirit of service and humanity.

Good show by Maharishi Vidhya Mandir students

Many students of Maharishi Vidhya Mandir Senior Secondary School in Chetpet secured more than 99 percent in JEE (Main) 2026 - Session 1, according to a press release from the school. More than 180 students have achieved the feat, according to the press release.

Started in 1983 with 75 students, today the school is among popular centres for learning, and its curriculum is based on consciousness-based education, the release adds.

Arena Animation opens centre in Nungambakkam



Arena Animation, a training institution in animation, visual effects and digital media education, has opened a centre in Nungambakkam. The new centre will offer industry-focused training to aspiring creators, says a press release.

Zamer Hussain, chief operating officer of Basilic Fly Studio, inaugurated the office.

Spread across approximately 2,500 square feet, the centre features a dedicated Visual Effects (VFX) lab with a professional green-screen setup, providing a specialised VFX production environment for students, the release adds. The centre will offer career-

focused programmes in animation, VFX, game development, graphic design, and UI/UX Design, aimed at preparing students for opportunities in the rapidly growing Animation, VFX, gaming, and comics (AVGC) sector, says the release.

Shajan Samuel, senior vice president and national sales head of Arena Animation, along with actor and advocate Sreenidhi Sudarshan participated.

Arena Animation is on the sixth floor of Apex Plaza, Number 3, Nungambakkam High Road, Thirumuthy Nagar.

Phone: 9039300064. Website: <https://www.arenaanimation.in/>

ONGC funds CCTV cameras

ONGC has funded installation of 90 CCTV cameras for the Greater Chennai Police under its Corporate Social Responsibility (CSR) programme.

The CCTV cameras were formally handed over by Uthaman Chukkasseri, Basin Manager, Cauvery-ONGC, to the Deputy Commissioner of Police, Anna Nagar District.

The surveillance system aims to im-



prove prevention of crime, improve traffic monitoring, and ensure quicker response to incidents in key public areas, says a press release.

ProNutramax introduces two brands

ProNutramax, a health drink company, has launched two brands: 'Pro Nutra Kidz' for the mind and body, and 'Authentic Natural Indian (ANI)', aimed at preserving traditional Indian cooking.

Pro Nutra Kidz comes in two flavours: classic vanilla and rich chocolate, designed to support strong bones, boost immunity and provide sustained energy.

ANI offers a variety of spices and instant mixes, including 'idli podi,' 'rasam,' 'sambar,' 'puliyocharai,' and 'rava idli' mixes.

Latha Dubai, founder of ProNutramax, in a release said, "Today's new-generation parents often find it hard to balance their kids' hectic school schedules with proper nutrition, while also trying to keep the authentic flavours of traditional home cooking."

Understanding this, ProNutramax has combined science-backed nutrition with the trusted taste of the past to bring back parent-approved nutrition to every family's table, said the release. For details, contact 95009 10040 98402 97720. Website : <https://pronutramax.com/>

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SHARON JESSICA MICHAEL

Anyone with normal vision would need just a quarter of a glance to distinguish a ₹50 note from a ₹500 note. For a visually impaired individual, any effort in that direction would require dependence on others. The Tamil Nadu state branch of National Association for the Blind (NAB) is seeking to cut out that dependence by distributing "Vision Wallets" to visually impaired individuals. On March 13, at its office in Kodungaiyur, it distributed these Vision Wallets to 15 visually impaired women, to mark International Women's Day. The 15 are part of a batch of 250 visually impaired individuals across Tamil Nadu to receive this assistive device. The Vision Wallets are sponsored by Synamedia India Pvt. Ltd., Tharamani; Reachem Laboratory Chemicals Pvt. Ltd.; and the Rotaract Clubs. Applications would open after this batch of 250 are served.

What is a Vision Wallet anyway? Developed by H Vision India Pvt. Ltd., the device allows users to instantly identify currency denominations and detect counterfeit notes without relying on a smartphone or internet connectivity. It resembles a conventional men's wallet fitted with a compact electronic module. Embedded sensors detect the currency note and relay the denomination through audio output in Hindi and English. Specially designed grooves guide the note into position from any corner, enabling the sensors to read it accurately and announce the value almost instantly without internet connectivity. The device came to NAB's attention after one of the organisation's secretaries encountered it at an assistive technology exhibition organised by Vellore Institute of Technology. Dipti Bhatia, CEO of NAB's Tamil Nadu branch, says it was obvious



A WALLET WITH 'EYES'

National Association for the Blind — Tamil Nadu has launched an initiative to distribute Vision Wallets to visually impaired individuals with an event organised at its office in Chennai on March 13. The assistive device spells out the denomination of a currency note



Snapshots of the event at NAB's Chennai office; and the Vision Wallet. PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

to them that it offered a practical solution. "Many people think visually impaired persons can simply use smartphones or Google Pay," she observes. "But not everyone owns a smartphone or is comfortable using one. Even existing apps require scanning and waiting, and sometimes the voice output is too soft or the scan fails. The wallet offers a simple and quick hands-on solution."

The priority list

The organisation received more than 250 applications

from across the State. However, limited funding meant only a small number

of wallets could be distributed in the first phase. Beneficiaries were selected based

on income: those earning less than ₹2 lakh annually received the device free of cost; those earning between ₹2 lakh and ₹5 lakh paid a nominal contribution of ₹500; and those earning above ₹5 lakh are expected to purchase it independently. The device carries an approximate market price of ₹3,600. Priority was also given to students and individuals who frequently handle cash such as street vendors, small traders and others whose livelihoods depend on regular cash transactions.

The initiative was spearheaded by Vikas, honorary secretary of the NAB Tamil Nadu branch. After testing it, he recognised its practicality immediately. "When I placed currency notes on the device, I found it to be very useful and practical," he said. The initiative also hit an early setback when an NGO that had initially planned to supply the wallets withdrew from the programme, by which point hundreds had already applied. "We felt we could not abandon them because the wallet could significantly improve their independence," said Vikas. The organisation turned to donors and supporters to sustain the project.

The origin story

The Vision Wallet itself originated from a moment of observation. In 2019, while pursuing product design, founder of H Vision India Pvt. Ltd., Hasin Vaidya visited the Blind People's Asso-

ciation in Ahmedabad and noticed a visually impaired man struggling to identify a ₹10 note after buying tea. "To make a payment of ten rupees, the person took around four to five minutes," he recalled. "Even after giving the note, he asked the tea seller to confirm if it was a ₹10 note." That moment led Hasin to rethink the wallet entirely. "I thought of making the wallet itself smart," he said. "In the same wallet where they keep their currency notes and documents, they should also be able to identify the notes." User feedback shaped several improvements. Battery life extended from 1.5 days to two days to nearly a month, with only an hour of charging required. The automatic power feature was replaced with a manual on-off switch, allowing users to activate the device only when needed. Some users asked for coin identification but it was not implemented because it was technically impractical. After years of development, the company launched its first production batch in 2024 and began collaborating with NGOs across India. Users who can afford the device can buy it directly online from the manufacturer, at hvision.in. NAB welcomes donors to support their initiative to distribute the device to visually impaired individuals. Donors can sponsor the cost of three or five wallets. NAB can be contacted at 9840917314.

A word from the beneficiaries

Mary from Pallikaranai earns her livelihood through chair re-caning. Running a business is tough, doing so as a visually challenged person, tougher still. The initiative by the Tamil Nadu branch of the National Association for the Blind (NAB), has taken one worry off her table. "Now I can confidently say that I am giving the correct amount without worrying about being cheated," says Mary.

Another beneficiary, Krithika, a first-year student of Madras Christian College, says this Vision Wallet would put an end to a dependence while shopping, "asking the person next to me about the denomination of the currency I was giving".



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